

sion; we are satisfied with living like free men, that is to say, like Christians;" "Thank God we Tuscans are different from every other nation." Of course one cannot take the author seriously! (I cannot, though a Tuscan myself). How could one ever take Malaparte seriously, since he does not take himself seriously! *Maledetti Toscani*, then, is a panegyric of Tuscans, but a panegyric full of paradoxes and irony. "One never grows tired of listening to them [Tuscans]: and one can never catch them uttering a profanity, a swear-word, never. (If, at times, they swear, they do it in a whisper, unwillingly, blushing, and only most rarely; they do it out of sheer necessity, and only when they are actually compelled to do it. They swear only when God, or some saint, has it in for them personally; the trouble is that God and the Saints always have it in for them.) In short, as everybody knows, they are shy, modest, lovable, generous and courteous. And it is only fair to recognize that, without Tuscany, Italy would be nothing but a slice of Europe."

Strange as it may seem at this point, the poetic is not completely absent from *Maledetti Toscani*. Some of the landscapes are deftly drawn, and with a true sense of the pictorial. "Oh the beautiful women of Leghorn, with their well-shaped shoulders, their round arms, and their foreheads spacious as a windowsill. Just like a windowsill overlooking the

sea. Where tall masts with white sails glide before pots of geraniums, and blue clouds cross a vermilion sky. The houses seem made of flesh, and it is indeed the rose-grey, the rose-yellow, the rose-green color of the walls that imparts to the houses a touch of young, firm and smooth flesh, where the marine sun relaxes, stretched out with open legs. On the façades and on the streets there are beautiful ripe-melon-like slices of sun, and at eventide a golden juice drips from the eaves and from the window shutters, a warm and aromatic juice which inebriates the swallows. And the swallows no longer dart across the rooftops with their piercing screeches, but float about with wide-spread wings, as if drunk. They totter through the sonorous air, and bump their heads against the patches of blue which the sunset leaves dangling over the roofs."

At the very beginning of his book, Malaparte says that, "In the presence of a Tuscan, everyone feels uneasy;" undoubtedly, non-Tuscans will feel uneasy in reading his latest work, that is, if they do not possess a good dose of humor, for humor is the main ingredient of the book. It is true that, like a good Tuscan, Malaparte paints a most flattering picture of Tuscans, but it is evident that he does it with tongue in cheek, and with the smile of Dante's devil who said to the shivering soul of Hell: "You did not think that I was a logician!"

[C. S.]

SITUATION OF CONTEMPORARY LYRIC POETRY

Two anthologies, of very different kinds and intents, seem usefully to reflect the situation of contemporary lyric poetry in Italy. One is *Antologia popolare di poeti del novecento* ("A popular anthology of nineteenth-century poetry"), by Vittorio Masselli and G. A. Cibotto (Florence: Vallecchi, 1956); the other is Enrico Falqui's *La giovane poesia: Saggio e repertorio* ("Young poetry: an essay and a collection," Rome: Colombo, 1956). Chronologically, the Masselli-Cibotto selections cover the period from Umberto Saba (born 1883) to Salvatore Quasimodo (born 1901); a second volume will follow. The book therefore includes, besides such "easier" poets as Jahier, Palazzeschi, Cardarelli, the major exponents of "difficult" or "hermetic" poetry, Montale, Ungaretti, and Quasimodo himself. The keyword of the book is, of course, the *popolare* of the title: it undertakes to make that poetry a part of the "popular" heritage. The compilers address the reader in plain language: "You are one of the many who during their school years have read poems by Dante, Petrarch, Foscolo, Leopardi, Carducci, Pascoli, d'Annunzio . . . but if you hear about twentieth-century poetry you perceive distinctly, at the bottom of your memory, only *La signorina Felicita* by Guido Gozzano. Of the other twentieth-century poets you have a

pale idea because no literary critic of our time has talked to you about them in simple language in the ordinary papers read by the ordinary citizen. If you have stumbled on a literary magazine, your breath failed . . ." Each group of selections includes a statement by the poet himself; some of these, as in the case of Palazzeschi or Ungaretti, have a significance that goes beyond the occasion. Each poem is preceded by a rather long analysis, of a very close and elementary type.

It is difficult to say whether an anthology of this sort will help make modern Italian poetry any more popular; a plausible view is that it rather memorializes a trend which existed in the first place; for years now, the young reader who cultivates poetry at all in Italy, has taken Montale and Quasimodo very much for granted; if he found a standard poetic aura, a prevailing poetic speech, as d'Annunzio's was to earlier generations, it is the one established by such poets as the *ermetici*. It is interesting to know that this anthology, which incidentally may be of particular use to foreign readers of Italian poetry, has now been widely adopted in secondary schools in Italy.

While the Masselli-Cibotto anthology places the "hermetic" poets practically in the position of schoolroom classics, the passing of poetic time is indicated even more sharply by Enrico Falqui's book—by the

fact that such a book should be conceivable at all. It is an anthology of post-World War II poets. It excludes not only the "classics" mentioned above but even anyone born before 1915. It manages nevertheless to assemble selections from as many as 98 young poets. Of these, only very few like Giorgio Bassani or Pier Paolo Pasolini have any reputation outside the little magazines (of which a considerable number have appeared more or less sporadically since 1945). Their poetic output, as is typical in our time everywhere, has been accompanied and supported by critical and polemic statements. On the whole, the most characteristic preoccupations seem to be with the contents and the communicability of poetry. As Falqui puts it in the introductory essay, where he attempts objectively to discern the main lines of opinion among the latest poets, they generally seem to favor the immersion of poetry into "the fullness of life, even at the risk of extra-poetic contaminations and even through a language which can sometimes show sharp closeness to spoken discourse" (p. 11), and a transition from "pure" to "impure" poetry: "If pure poetry implies 'total detachment from life,' then impure poetry is better. Break the circle. Jump across the ditch. From abstract to concrete. From monologue to dialogue. From isolation to engagement. From evasion to communion. From fragment to structure." This sounds hardly new or far-

etched; it becomes relevant if it is supported by a large body of relatively respectable poetry. Some of the results can be observed even externally, in such elements as the greater length of poems and their discursive quality, and the immediate currency of some of their themes. The keywords of the "new" trends may again be the two most fashionable words in the Italian cultural-political jargon of today: *dialogo* and *istanza*. *Dialogo* in this case implies a craving for the communications of speech and ideas beyond the "private formulae" of the "hermetic" tradition; *istanza* is the issue, the problem, the search for cultural and moral "engagement." Some of this poetry can indeed be bracketed under the two most inclusively formulated *istanze*, the social and the religious, as Falqui points out (pp. 31-32). For all this, drawing too sharp a line of demarcation between the new poets and the newly acquired "classics" would be unwarranted and misleading, however polemical the attitude of some of the younger ones may be toward their predecessors. Actually a closer inspection of their poetic idiom would reveal the almost constant presence of the linguistic atmosphere in which they grew; at first glance, the most definite general influence seems to be that of Salvatore Quasimodo. But only the study of definite illustrations will help clarify the matter in any concrete sense.

[P. M. P.]

UNORTHODOXY AND CULTURE

In his latest book, *Saper leggere* ("How to Read," Milan: Garzanti, 1956), Professor Prezzolini has put aside the overwhelming bitterness characteristic of his latest books and has presented us with an interesting, if somewhat unorthodox volume. Orthodoxy has never been a "forte" of Prezzolini and we are not surprised. What is surprising is that he should have taken such great pains to present unorthodoxly a very orthodox concept of culture.

At bottom the book is an attempt to lead the uninitiated into the world of learning. The question is what sort of learning; for there seem to be various kinds: popular, individual, and the learning which academic tradition has preserved. Prezzolini is a self-taught man — a fact which anyone who has known him personally or is acquainted with his writing is not prone to forget easily. There is little doubt that no other accomplishment of his life has given Giuseppe Prezzolini as much satisfaction as that of having become a university professor without a university degree. The book then is for those who by choice, or by circumstances, have decided to take the lonely road to culture. According to the author he intended his work for Italians, but we find so many references suggestive of American methods of learning and research, not only in orientation,

but in the very mechanics of the process, that it seems doubtful that Italian students could profit by it. Suffice it to mention the profound differences in the organization, workings, and concept of a library in the two countries. Furthermore, and in spite of the repeated denials of academic culture as such, Prezzolini is really trying to popularize those same orthodox, academic, and traditional methods of learning he so much disdains. As a matter of fact he does such a good job of it that one might suggest, *horribile dictu*, that the book be adopted as a school text.

Having said all this, one can freely admit that, as usual, Prezzolini is a very interesting, acutely intelligent, and very instructive writer. Most interesting is Prezzolini's concept of culture which he regards as a "personal adventure" which, he adds, can and must exist only within the framework of a social group. On the question of instruments of culture (libraries, bibliographies, reference books, etc.) he makes a disturbing statement: "Actually, in no human activity do instruments have great importance, and in the field of culture they perhaps have none at all." I say this is a disturbing statement because a good part of the book is devoted precisely to a very minute examination of these very instruments. Disappointing is the fact that Prezzolini makes no attempt to interpret culture in its philosophical implications. He had done this much earlier in his